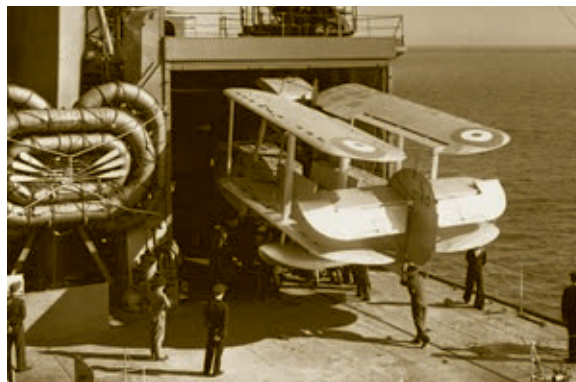


decisive encounter, but it was a turning point in the history of warfare. For the first time, two naval forces had fought using carrier aircraft alone, far beyond the range of even the most powerful warship's guns.

Seaplanes and flying boats

Carrier aircraft were far from being the only aerial presence at sea during World War II. Warships were generally equipped with catapult-launched seaplanes for reconnaissance – aircraft such as the slow and ungainly Supermarine Walrus, much loved by its British crews, or the German Arado Ar 196. And large flying boats such as the American Consolidated Catalina and Martin Mariner and the British Short Sunderland (a military version of the Empire flying boats that cruised to Cape Town and Sydney before the war) also patrolled the oceans, searching for enemy submarines and ships, as well as fulfilling an invaluable air-sea rescue role. Although slow by the standards of most World War II aircraft, the Catalinas and Sunderlands had invaluable range – the Catalina could stay in the air for 24 hours. These giants were not so gentle either, packing considerable defensive firepower, along with their bombs and depth-charges. The Sunderland became so noted for fending off harrying attacks



COMPACT WALRUS

A shipborne Walrus flying boat is brought out of its hangar, wings folded for compact storage. The Walrus would be launched by catapult from the deck and land alongside the ship on returning from its mission.

He 111s also struck with devastating effect.

The convoys needed air cover to stop these attacks. One desperate measure in the early days was to catapult a Hawker Hurricane from a merchant ship – a once-only mission, since the pilot's only recourse when he ran out of fuel was to ditch in the sea and hope to be picked up. Later, escort carriers provided a less wasteful solution,

although there were never enough of them. Long-range flying boats, like the Catalinas and Sunderlands, patiently quartered the ocean in search of submarines. At first they were mostly limited to deterring U-boats from surfacing, but by 1942–43, the Allied aircraft were equipped with improved radar and depth-charges, and they became more aggressive.

Allied commanders were slow to devote adequate air resources to the Battle of the Atlantic, but the allocation of long-range Consolidated B-24 Liberator bombers to the ocean in 1943 marked a decisive turning point. From then until the end of the war Allied aircraft imposed such heavy losses on the German U-boat fleet that it ceased to pose a major threat to merchant shipping.

Warship defenses

No one could accuse traditional naval commanders of ignoring air power in their war preparations. They had taken great trouble to arm their warships against air attack – the density

by Luftwaffe fighters over the Bay of Biscay that the Germans nicknamed it “the Porcupine.”

Convoy protection

One of the most important uses of aircraft in World War II was for the defense of merchant convoys. German U-boats and aircraft took a heavy toll on merchant shipping sailing to and from Britain. In the winter of 1940, Fw 200 Condors based in occupied Norway and France launched long-range bombing raids on Atlantic convoys. Where shipping sailed closer to land – for example, the Arctic convoys from Britain to the Soviet ports of Murmansk and Arkhangelsk passing Norway – shorter range Ju 88s and

AIRCRAFT AGAINST SUBMARINES

Aircraft proved an effective answer to German U-boats in the Battle of the Atlantic. Left, the crew of an RAF Coastal Command Sunderland flying boat keep watch on patrol over the Atlantic. Below, an American aircraft escorts a convoy of merchant ships bringing vital supplies across the ocean from the United States to beleaguered Britain.

